

Employee Handbook

People, expectations and workplace practices

Document control	Current issue
Document ID	EH-001
Version / status	1.0 / Current test edition
Effective date	September 1, 2026
Next scheduled review	September 1, 2027
Owner	People Operations
Applies to	Waterfront, Old Town and North Park

Fictional material for AI assistant testing

All business details, policies, amounts, roles, contacts and examples in this document were invented for document extraction, chunking, retrieval and question-answering tests. They do not represent a real employer or an adopted legal, food-safety or consumer policy.

This PDF contains selectable text, numbered policy sections, realistic exceptions and cross-document references. Use the current versions of all three documents together.

Contents and document map

Find the governing section before applying a threshold or exception. Each section begins on a new page so retrieved answers can cite both the section ID and PDF page.

Section	PDF page
EH-01 Employment and responsibilities	3
EH-02 Schedules, attendance and coverage	4
EH-03 Timekeeping, payroll and breaks	5
EH-04 Leave, benefits and employee purchases	6
EH-05 Conduct, reporting and fair treatment	7
EH-06 Appearance, safety and information	8
EH-07 Training, performance and transitions	9
EH-08 Practical examples and reference index	10

The three-document set

EH-001 Employee Handbook: scheduling, pay processes, leave, employee conduct, benefits and training.
OM-001 Operations Manual: opening, service, cash, inventory, food handling, cleaning, closing and incidents.
RP-001 Refund Policy: eligibility, approval authority, amounts, payment methods, cancellations and recovery records.

Interpretation notes

A specific exception overrides a general rule only within the stated scope. Approval authority does not create eligibility. Missing facts should remain unknown: do not supply personal pay rates, local statutory requirements, supplier-specific temperatures or platform terms that are not present in the source.

All three documents share version 1.0 and the September 1, 2026 effective date. No superseded policies are included.

EH-01

Employment and responsibilities

Purpose and scope

Harbor & Hearth Gelato Cafe is a fictional three-location business used in this test document set. Its company-operated locations are Waterfront, Old Town, and North Park. This handbook applies to hourly team members, shift leads, assistant general managers, general managers, and regional support employees. Temporary agency workers follow site conduct and safety rules; their agency administers employment benefits.

The Employee Handbook controls personnel practices. The Operations Manual (OM-001) controls store procedures, and the Refund Policy (RP-001) controls financial remedies for customers. A manager may not use an informal store custom to replace a written policy. If two documents appear inconsistent, stop the affected decision and ask the document owner to resolve it; do not invent an exception.

Roles and escalation

Team members prepare products, assist customers, keep work areas clean, and record work accurately. A shift lead is the manager on duty (MOD) when assigned on the posted schedule. The MOD allocates stations, coordinates breaks, handles immediate service issues, and signs daily logs. An assistant general manager (AGM) supports scheduling, inventory, and coaching. The general manager (GM) owns store results and staffing; the regional director approves decisions above GM authority.

People Operations owns this handbook. Routine questions go to the GM or people@harborhearth.example. Employees may contact People Operations directly when a concern involves their manager. These are fictional example addresses, not monitored contact channels.

Employment records and introductory period

Employees review their name, contact information, emergency contact, and payroll details during onboarding and report changes within seven calendar days. Bank changes are entered through the employee portal, never through a shared store email account. Managers cannot ask staff to send passwords or full bank details in chat.

The introductory period is 60 calendar days, with check-ins near days 14, 30, and 60. It is a training and feedback period, not a guarantee of continued employment or a delay in access to reporting channels. Required training is paid. This fictional handbook does not establish employment-contract terms or jurisdiction-specific legal entitlements.

Document terms: a calendar day includes weekends and holidays. A business day means Monday through Friday, excluding company-observed holidays. Time-based store deadlines use the location's local time.

EH-02

Schedules, attendance and coverage

Publishing schedules and requesting time away

The workweek runs Monday at 12:00 a.m. through Sunday at 11:59 p.m. Schedules are published in the scheduling portal by Thursday at 3:00 p.m. for the following Monday-Sunday period. Employees review each new schedule within 24 hours and report conflicts promptly. Managers communicate later changes directly and record the employee's acknowledgment.

Routine time-off requests should arrive at least 14 calendar days before the first requested day. Requests are evaluated by coverage, prior approved commitments, and submission order. A request is pending until approved in the portal. Emergency absence, illness, and protected leave requests use the appropriate reporting process and are not rejected merely because 14 days of notice was impossible.

Late arrivals and unexpected absences

Call the MOD as soon as an absence or late arrival is known; the target is at least two hours before the shift begins. If nobody answers, leave a voicemail, send a portal message, and call the GM. A text to a coworker alone does not complete the process. When an emergency prevents advance notice, report as soon as reasonably possible and explain the communication delay.

If a team member has not arrived or contacted the store 15 minutes after the scheduled start, the MOD attempts contact and records the event as a possible no-call/no-show. The GM reviews the facts before any action. Employees are never required to find replacement coverage before reporting illness or an emergency.

Shift swaps and extra work

Employees may propose swaps in the portal at least 24 hours before the affected shift. A qualified replacement and MOD approval are required; a coworker's agreement alone does not transfer responsibility. A last-minute request goes directly to the MOD. Managers review station qualifications, scheduled rest, and projected overtime before approving a swap.

An employee who is asked to stay late must record all additional work. Advance approval is required for overtime scheduling, but all time actually worked is recorded and paid even when approval was missed. Managers address the approval issue separately from payroll.

Example

A Saturday shift starts at 10:00 a.m. An employee becomes ill at 8:30 a.m. They call the MOD immediately rather than waiting to find coverage. Because only 90 minutes remain, the two-hour target was not met, but the MOD records when the illness became known instead of automatically treating it as misconduct.

EH-03

Timekeeping, payroll and breaks

Clocking in and correcting time

Clock in before doing any work, including opening preparation, meetings, required online lessons, cleaning, or closing counts. Clock out only after all work is complete. Employees may not clock in for one another. A forgotten punch must be reported through a time-correction request stating the date, actual start or end time, and reason.

Employees review punches by Monday at 10:00 a.m. after the workweek closes. Managers review corrections by Monday at noon. A later-reported mistake is still investigated and corrected; missing the review target does not erase worked time. Every manager edit requires a reason and an audit trail visible to the employee.

Payroll calendar and pay questions

The fictional company pays biweekly on Friday for the two workweeks ending the preceding Sunday. When the normal payday is a company-observed banking holiday, payroll targets the preceding business day. Pay statements separate regular hours, overtime hours, adjustments, reimbursements, and applicable deductions. Individual pay rates and tax elections are private employee records.

Report a pay discrepancy to payroll@harborhearth.example or People Operations. Payroll acknowledges a report within two business days and targets resolution within five business days after receiving necessary information. The actual correction date is communicated in writing. Do not wait for a performance review to raise a missing-hours concern.

Break planning and interruptions

For this fictional test policy, shifts longer than five hours include a 30-minute uninterrupted meal period beginning before the end of the fifth hour. Paid 10-minute rest periods are planned at one for shifts of 3.5 through 6 hours, two for shifts over 6 through 10 hours, and three for shifts over 10 through 14 hours. Longer shifts require People Operations review before scheduling. These are dataset rules, not a statement of local law.

The MOD assigns station coverage so breaks can be taken. Employees remain clocked in for paid rest periods. They clock out for a meal only when relieved of all duties. If a meal is interrupted by work, record the interruption, restore worked time, and tell the MOD to arrange an uninterrupted meal and payroll review. Required legal or local addenda take precedence over this sample schedule.

Tips and reimbursements

Tips are handled through the approved payroll process; managers may not use tips to offset cash shortages. Necessary approved business purchases require an itemized receipt and reimbursement request within 30 calendar days. Personal travel to a normal work location is not a reimbursable purchase under this fictional policy.

EH-04

Leave, benefits and employee purchases

Paid time off in this test dataset

Regular employees accrue one hour of general paid time off (PTO) for every 30 hours worked, beginning on the first day of employment. The balance cap is 80 hours; accrual pauses at the cap and resumes when the balance falls below it. Up to 40 unused hours carry into the next calendar year. Requests may be made in one-hour increments through the portal.

General PTO can be requested once available; the 60-day introductory period does not create a separate waiting period. The GM approves routine scheduling requests using EH-02. PTO is not a substitute for any separately required sick leave or protected leave. This test set does not specify statutory leave balances, carryover requirements, or separation payout rules; People Operations must supply the applicable addendum.

Illness, emergencies and accommodations

Employees who may be unable to handle food safely must notify the MOD before starting food duties. Do not pressure an ill employee to work at a food station. The MOD removes the employee from the affected assignment and follows OM-06; People Operations handles leave and any required return-to-work process. Employees should not include detailed medical histories in the shared shift log.

Accommodation requests can be made directly to People Operations without discussing private details with coworkers. The company reviews the work limitation, possible adjustments, and any appropriate documentation confidentially. Supervisors must not promise a specific medical or leave determination from this handbook alone.

Employee discount and shift refreshment

Active employees receive a 30 percent discount on eligible food and nonalcoholic beverages purchased for personal use, limited to \$25 of menu-price purchases per employee per calendar day. Gift cards, catering, delivery-platform orders, retail merchandise, and purchases for resale are excluded. The employee discount cannot be combined with another promotion. A different employee must ring the transaction, and the purchaser may not approve their own adjustment.

For a worked shift of at least four hours, an employee may receive one standard hot coffee, iced coffee, or tea up to 16 ounces without charge. Specialty add-ons are paid separately. The drink must be entered using the SHIFT-DRINK button before it is prepared. Unrecorded consumption is not an employee benefit.

Example and benefit boundaries

An eligible \$20 food purchase receives a \$6 discount before tax. The remaining menu-price allowance for that day is \$5. Benefits enrollment, insurance premiums, retirement matching, and statutory leave amounts are intentionally unspecified in this dataset; the assistant should not invent them.

EH-05

Conduct, reporting and fair treatment

Professional standards

Treat coworkers, applicants, suppliers, and customers with respect. Harassment, discrimination, threats, intimidation, retaliation, and deliberate humiliation are prohibited. Managers apply standards consistently and document facts rather than assumptions about someone's background or personal circumstances. Employees may disagree with a decision respectfully and request a review.

Workplace conduct rules cover store shifts, training, work-related travel, company events, and work messaging channels. A disagreement in a private social channel can still require review when it creates threats or targeted harassment at work. Employees are not asked to waive legitimate workplace rights or refrain from lawful discussions about pay and conditions.

Reporting a concern

Report a concern to the MOD, GM, or People Operations. If the concern involves one of those people, skip that person and use another reporting route. A useful report includes dates, what occurred, involved roles, witnesses, and available messages. A report may be made even when the employee does not know the exact policy title or cannot supply every detail.

People Operations acknowledges a report within two business days, identifies an investigator or next step, and aims to provide an initial status update within five business days. Those are response targets, not promises that every investigation finishes in five days. Information is shared only as needed, but absolute anonymity cannot be guaranteed when facts must be investigated.

Retaliation and immediate safety

Employees must not be punished for a good-faith report or participation in an investigation. Suspected retaliation, such as a threat or unexplained adverse schedule change after reporting, should be raised immediately with People Operations. Making a report in good faith is different from knowingly fabricating evidence.

For immediate threats or danger, move to safety, alert the MOD when safe, and contact emergency services as appropriate. Do not wait for the normal two-business-day acknowledgment process. OM-09 covers store emergency response and incident preservation.

Conflicts, gifts and outside work

Disclose a personal relationship that could affect hiring, scheduling, purchasing, or discipline decisions. A manager must not approve a close relative's reimbursement or their own refund. Supplier gifts above \$25 in value require GM review; cash gifts from suppliers are prohibited. Outside work is allowed when it does not misuse company information or interfere with scheduled responsibilities.

EH-06

Appearance, safety and information

Uniform and personal readiness

Wear the company shirt or apron, clean dark trousers, and enclosed slip-resistant shoes. Clothing must be clean enough for the assigned work, and hair must be restrained for food handling. Store-issued aprons remain at the location for laundering. The MOD provides a spare apron when contamination occurs during a shift.

Jewelry or accessories that interfere with safe handling must be removed or appropriately secured. Requests involving religion, disability, pregnancy, or another accommodation need are referred to People Operations. A manager should find safe temporary work while a request is reviewed rather than dismiss it without consideration.

Safety responsibilities

Employees report damaged equipment, spills, pests, missing guards, and blocked exits immediately. Place a warning sign at a spill and arrange cleanup; do not assume the sign alone resolves the hazard. Only trained staff operate equipment requiring certification in the training log. Do not defeat guards, attempt electrical repairs, or mix cleaning products.

Handwashing, allergen precautions, cleaning procedures, and food-control records are governed by OM-06 and OM-07. Employees may stop a task when they reasonably believe it is unsafe and ask the MOD to review it. Store productivity targets do not override a safety hold.

Phones, systems and customer information

Personal phones are stored away from active food preparation except for an approved work or accessibility need. After touching a phone, perform required hand hygiene before returning to food tasks. Company tablets and POS accounts are used for business purposes and locked when unattended. Employees use their own assigned login and never share a manager PIN.

Access customer information only for the transaction or case assigned. Never photograph a payment card, copy a security code, or put a full card number into notes. Order identifiers and the last four card digits may be used for a permitted receipt lookup. Customer phone numbers collected for recovery stay in the approved case system, not personal contacts.

Public posts and lost property

Only authorized company spokespeople publish statements on behalf of the business. Staff may not post customer complaints, receipts, surveillance images, or employee records to personal accounts. This rule protects confidential records and does not prohibit lawful discussion of working conditions.

Give found property to the MOD, who records the date, location, brief description, and storage location. Do not search a found phone or wallet beyond what is necessary for the approved return process. The store retains ordinary lost property for 30 calendar days before GM-directed disposition.

EH-07

Training, performance and transitions

Required training pathway

Before working independently, a team member completes orientation, timekeeping, hand hygiene, allergen awareness, POS basics, and an observed station demonstration. A trainer records completion in the training log. Reading a checklist alone is not a practical sign-off. The employee can ask for another demonstration whenever the task or equipment is unfamiliar.

New starters complete required core modules within their first 10 worked shifts. Staff refresh allergen, emergency, and payment-data training every 12 months. A person with an expired critical station qualification is reassigned to approved work until the refresher is completed. All required refreshers are paid work.

Performance reviews and coaching

The GM holds introductory check-ins near days 14, 30, and 60 and then a documented performance conversation every six months. Reviews consider reliability, service quality, safety practices, teamwork, and role competence. Sales results alone are not sufficient evidence of strong performance if the employee bypasses safety or payment controls.

Coaching normally starts with a clear explanation of the issue, an opportunity to respond, an expected change, and a review date. A typical improvement window is 30 calendar days, adjusted to the facts. Serious safety incidents, threats, theft, or deliberate falsification may require immediate removal from the assignment and a separate investigation; discipline is not a rigid automatic ladder.

Reviewing a decision

An employee may request People Operations review of a written corrective decision within five business days after receiving it. Include the decision date, the disputed facts, and any supporting information. People Operations targets a response within 10 business days and communicates when more time is needed. An employee may still report a safety or retaliation concern after that review window.

Transfers and departure

Employees seeking a store transfer should discuss available roles with the GM and People Operations. A transfer requires an approved opening and training confirmation; it does not automatically change pay. Employees are encouraged to provide 14 calendar days of resignation notice when practical, but the handbook does not make earned pay dependent on that notice.

On the last shift, return keys, badges, uniforms assigned for return, and company devices. The GM submits an access-removal request for the effective departure time and checks outstanding expense claims. Final-pay timing, unused-leave payout, and benefits continuation are governed by applicable arrangements not specified in this fictional dataset.

EH-08

Practical examples and reference index

Example 1 - An unapproved shift exchange

Jordan asks Casey to cover a 2:00 p.m. shift. Casey agrees in a personal text, but no manager approves it. Jordan remains assigned under EH-02. The MOD checks whether Casey is qualified and whether the change would create scheduling issues, then records a decision. The assistant should not treat a friendly agreement as an approved schedule change.

Example 2 - Work during an unpaid meal

A cashier clocks out for lunch and is called back for six minutes to resolve a register issue. Under EH-03, those six minutes are recorded as work, the interruption is reported, and the MOD arranges an uninterrupted meal and payroll review. The cashier is not told to leave the timecard unchanged because the interruption was short.

Example 3 - A refund and an employee discount

A team member rings a discounted personal purchase and later wants a refund. Another authorized employee must review and process the transaction. The refund is based on the amount actually paid, not the menu price. Personnel rules on self-approval come from EH-04; eligibility and approval limits come from RP-02 and RP-04.

Example 4 - Information the handbook does not contain

A question asks for an employee's personal hourly rate or the exact retirement match. Neither is provided here. The appropriate response is that the dataset does not specify the answer, with a referral to payroll records or People Operations. General statements about benefits must not be turned into invented amounts.

Question topic	Primary reference
Schedule publication, lateness, shift coverage	EH-02
Punch edits, payday, breaks, expenses	EH-03
PTO, employee discount, shift drink	EH-04
Harassment, retaliation, gifts, conflicts	EH-05
Uniform, phones, customer data, property	EH-06
Training deadlines, coaching, resignation	EH-07
Safe service and incident response	OM-06, OM-07 and OM-09
Customer remedies and refund authority	RP-01 through RP-08

Acknowledgment: employees confirm receipt and know where to ask questions. Acknowledgment does not establish agreement to unspecified legal terms. This entire publication is fictional material for document-ingestion and retrieval testing.